

R' Moshe Oelbaum wrote a very moving piece in the קול שמהת תורה Gazette for פרשת נשא, which I want to say over here. It's something worth sharing with as many people as possible.

He quotes a story written by R' Avi Wiesenfeld. The period towards the end of World War II was one of the darkest and most challenging times for the Jewish people. Amidst the horrors of Holocaust, there were still moments of incredible resilience and even small glimmers of light that emerged in the most unexpected ways. One such story is about a man who, despite the devastation around him, managed to summon the strength to uphold his commitment to Torah.

In a certain shul, a man made an unusual invitation to a siyum. He walked through the entire shul personally inviting each person to attend. The guests were curious, wondering what the significance of this siyum was, especially since it wasn't tied to a typical celebration.

When the man began to speak, he shared a moving story from his time in the concentration camp. He recalled how one of the men who slept next to him would constantly be mumbling words. At first, he did not understand what this man was doing. But one night, the man revealed a special request. He told him that he had been reviewing the entire ש"ס by heart. He was only missing one נזיר מסכתא. He feared he would not survive the war and asked that if his friend survived, could he please complete the נזיר מסכתא on his behalf. The man was struck by the holiness of this request, especially in the middle of such unimaginable suffering. And the next day, the man was gone. The survivor promised himself he would keep his word, and he survived the war.

Though it took time, he eventually not only acquired נזיר מסכתא, he mastered it by heart. At the siyum he said: this is not a siyum on just נזיר. It's not even a siyum on the entire ש"ס. This is a siyum on a Yid who never gave up, even in the darkest times. This is a siyum on a Yid who showed us that no matter how much the world takes away from us, they can never take away our Torah. It is this Torah that keeps us going, and it gives us life, no matter the circumstances. A powerful story, worth hearing and worth repeating.

